Arthur G. Tansley



A free-thinking Fabian socialist and atheist, Arthur Tansley was one of the most influential ecologists of the 20th century. Born in London in 1871, he studied biology at University College London, where he later taught. In 1902, he founded the journal *New Phytologist* and he later established the British Ecological Society, becoming founding editor of its *Journal of Ecology*. In 1923, he took a break from teaching to study psychology with Sigmund Freud in Vienna. He was later Sherardian Professor of Botany at the University of Oxford. He retired in 1937, but maintained a special interest in conservation. Tansley was appointed the first Chairman of the UK's Nature Conservancy in 1950, five years before his death.

Key works

1922 *Types of British Vegetation*

1922 *Elements of Plant Ecology*

1923 *Practical Plant Ecology*

1935 "The use and abuse of vegetational terms and concepts," *Ecology*

1939 *The British Islands and Their Vegetation*

See also: Animal ecology • The food chain • Energy flow through ecosystems • The biosphere • The Gaia hypothesis • Environmental feedback loops • Nature's contributions to people